



Plants for roof and terrace gardens

Bright and breezy, roof gardens demand windproof plants that are happy basking in full sun and thrive in pots or well-drained soil.

Most roofs and terraces are container gardens. However, weight restrictions often apply, so opt for lighter pots made from galvanized metal and man-made materials, or try wooden raised beds and troughs for a rustic design. Also, consider investing in an automatic watering system because the sun and wind quickly dry out the soil, especially in the height of summer. Despite these limitations, roof terraces offer plenty of range. Shrubs and small trees provide height, structure, and shade, while roses, perennials, and annuals lend themselves to romantic schemes, and flax and grasses complement modern designs.



PERENNIAL SMALL

Agastache aurantiaca

GIANT HYSSOP This upright perennial has gray-green scented leaves. From mid- to late summer, it bears long-lasting spikes of small tubular flowers. 'Apricot Sprite' (above) has pale orange blooms. Plant it in groups in a bed or container.

↑20in (50cm) ↔3ft (1m)

☀ Z6–10 (N)



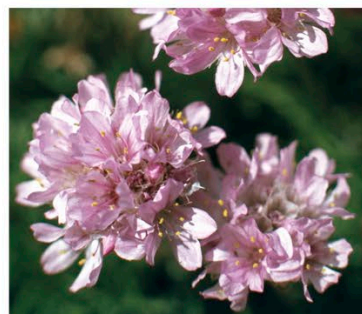
PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Anthemis tinctoria

GOLDEN MARGUERITE This clump-forming, low-growing perennial forms a mat of finely cut green leaves. In summer, it becomes speckled with a mass of daisy-like white or yellow flowers held on slender stems. 'E.C. Buxton' (above) has lemon-yellow flowers.

↑↔3ft (1m)

☀ Z3–8



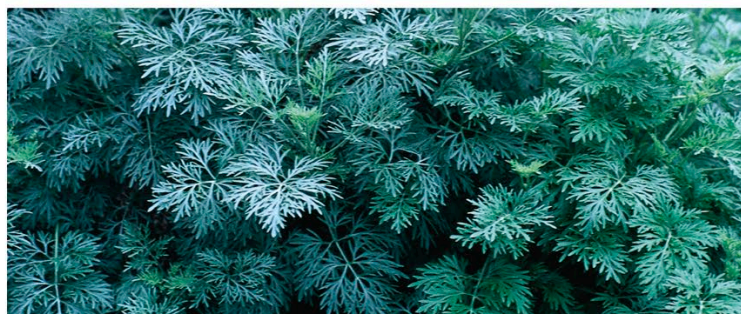
PERENNIAL SMALL

Armeria maritima

THRIFT This is a small mound-forming perennial with grasslike green leaves. In summer, it becomes dotted with heads of small, round white or pink flowers. Suitable for small pots, raised beds, or on exposed green roofs.

↑4in (10cm) ↔6in (15cm)

☀ Z4–8 (N)



SHRUB SMALL

Artemisia 'Powis Castle'

WORMWOOD A clump-forming semievergreen subshrub with fernlike silvery gray leaves that make an excellent foil for other plants. Yellow pompom flowers may appear in summer, but are best removed to retain its silvery foliage effect.

↑↔3ft (1m)

☀ Z7–9



SHRUB SMALL

Buxus sempervirens 'Suffruticosa'

COMMON BOXWOOD A compact, slow-growing evergreen shrub with woody stems of small oval green leaves; clip into architectural shapes and topiary. Grow in a pot, or use as a low hedge or bed edging.

↑3ft (1m) ↔5ft (1.5m)

☀ (I) Z6–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

Calamagrostis x acutiflora

FEATHER REED GRASS A clump-forming deciduous grass with long, arching green leaves. Tall bronze flower heads, borne in summer, fade to buff. The seedheads give winter interest. Use as a screen or backdrop; cut back in early spring.

↑6ft (1.8m) ↔4ft (1.2m)

☀ Z5–9



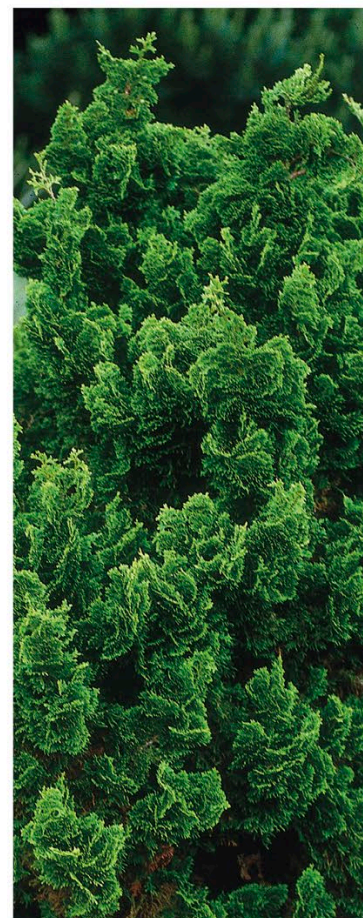
TREE SMALL

Carpinus betulus

EUROPEAN HORNBEAM This deciduous tree produces oval, prominently veined dark green leaves that turn yellow and orange in fall; young stems retain the dried foliage in winter. Cut it into a hedge on a roof terrace.

↑15ft (5m) as a hedge ↔70ft (20m)

☀ Z4–8



SHRUB SMALL

Chamaecyparis obtusa 'Rigid Dwarf'

HINOKI CYPRESS This compact, dwarf evergreen conifer makes a cone of dark green leaves. Use it as a foil for drought-tolerant plants on a roof terrace or plant in a large container of soil-based potting mix.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀ Z4–8